Programming and Data Analysis for Scientists

C++ Workshop 1

The shell and C++



University of BRISTOL

Prof Stephen Clark

SCIF20002

The shell and C++

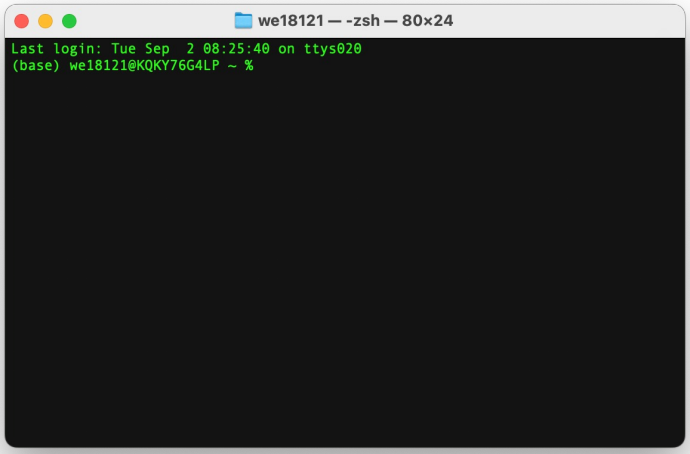
The purpose of this workshop is to introduce the C++ programming language. The *learning objectives* are:

- Learn some basic shell command line instructions
- Appreciate the advantages and uses of C++
- Understand what compilation of C++ code means
- Compile, run and post-process data from a simple C++ computation

Using the **shell** terminal

Back in the 1970's a *terminal* was a physical device for logging into a mainframe. These days it refers to a minimal text input and output graphical application emulating this device.



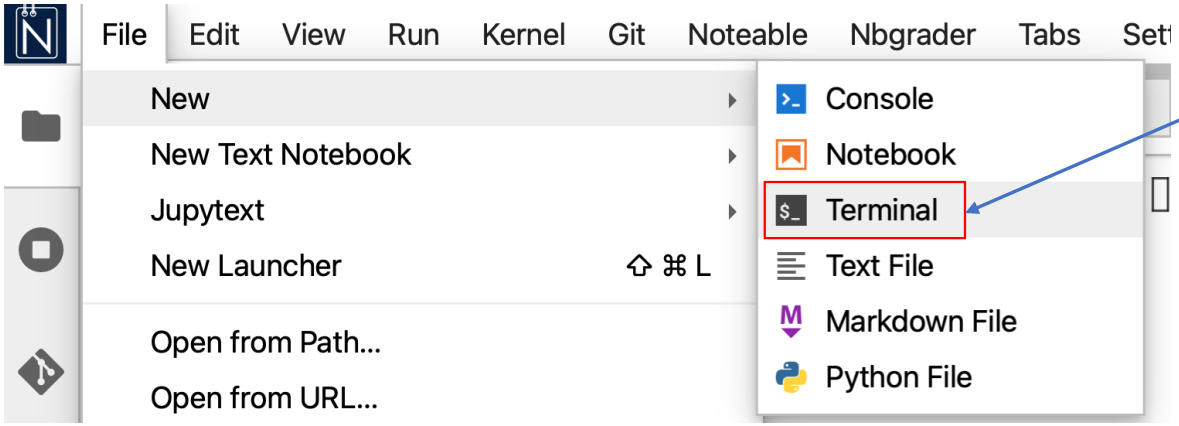


The *shell* is a command-line interpreter program. You type commands into the terminal, which sends them to the shell (like `Bash` or `Zsh`) for execution and the return results are displayed back in the terminal window.

While primitive in appearance the shell is extremely powerful. Any interactions with a high-performance computing facility will be via a shell.

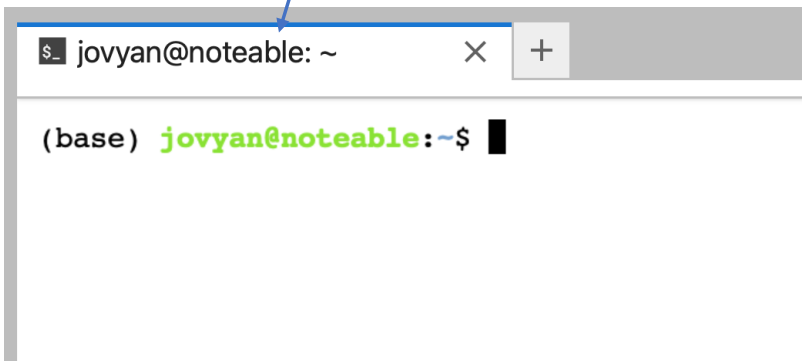
Start a shell on *Noteable*

You are already familiar with the ***Noteable*** server for running your Python Jupyter lab. The same resource can be used here. Start up Jupyter server …



Create Terminal session

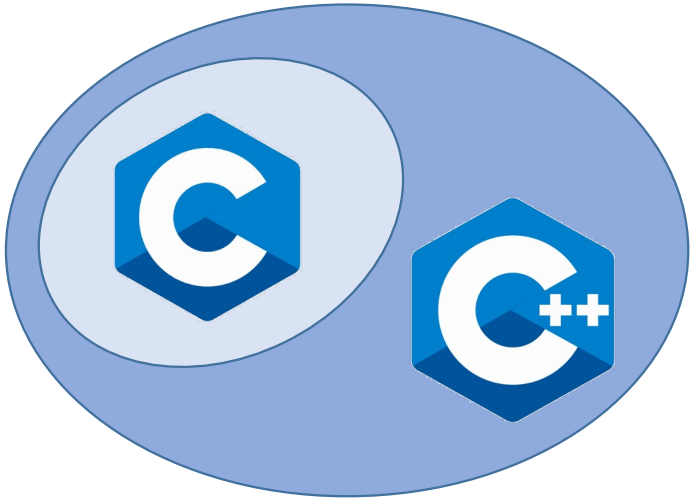
It appears as a new tab in the Jupyter lab in your browser



We can run shell commands here that will be executed on the Noteable server.

What are C and C++?

C is a procedural programming language developed in 1972. It is a light-weight mid to low-level language developed for systems programming.



C++ is a superset of C first developed in 1985 to enhance it to include object orientated formalism.

C++ uses C syntax along with many new extensions. It continues to be updated and evolve.

Elegant base syntax of C is the *lingua franca* of modern programming. Not only C++, but Java, C#, as well as Python inherited many key features from it.

Why bother to learn C++ now?



Legacy, maturity and ecosystem. It has been around for over 40 years. Unix, Mac OS, Linux, Windows, Google's Android OS are all written and continue to be developed in C++. Most problems have a C++ solution already written.



Since it is compiled it is **fast**! Most new computationally intensive applications like machine learning, scientific computing, virtual machines, device drivers, high-frequency trading, video games … are all written in C++.

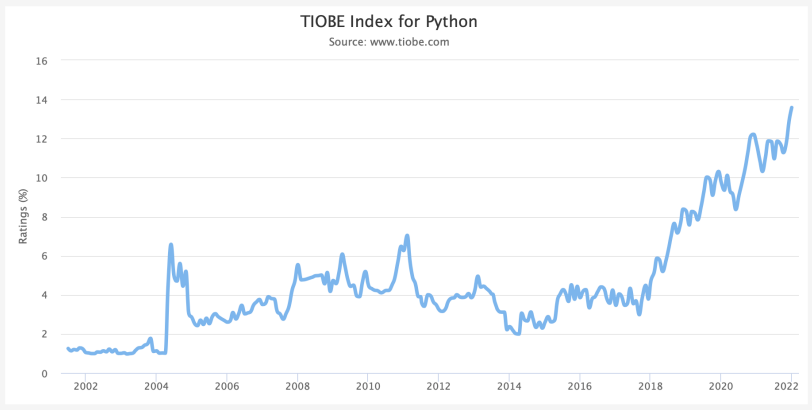


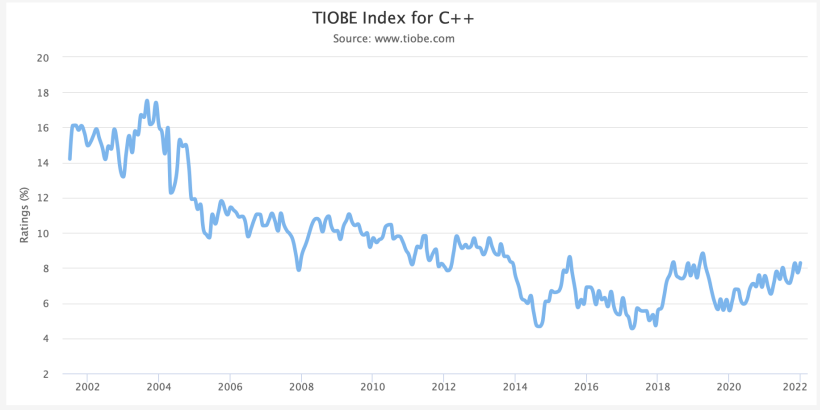
Since it is compiled it can be **small**! For embedded devices powering the IoT memory and processing is limited (due to power consumption and physical size) so their firmware is almost always written in C++.

How popular are C and C++ currently?

Oct 2025	Oct 2024	Change	Programming Language	Ratings	Change
1	1		Python	24.45%	+2.55%
2	4	↑	C	9.29%	+0.91%
3	2	↓	C++	8.84%	-2.77%
4	3	↓	Java	8.35%	-2.15%
5	5		C#	6.94%	+1.32%
6	6		JavaScript	3.41%	-0.13%
7	7		Visual Basic	3.22%	+0.87%
8	8		Go	1.92%	-0.10%

C and C++ still **very** well used.





Source: tiobe.com

But … 

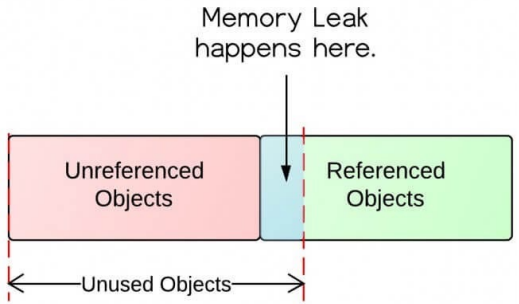
Is it necessary in the age of AI?

AI can help write code in C++, but you must decide whether it solves the right problem, whether the results are credible, and whether it uses resources sensibly. We will learn enough C++ for you to make informed decisions.



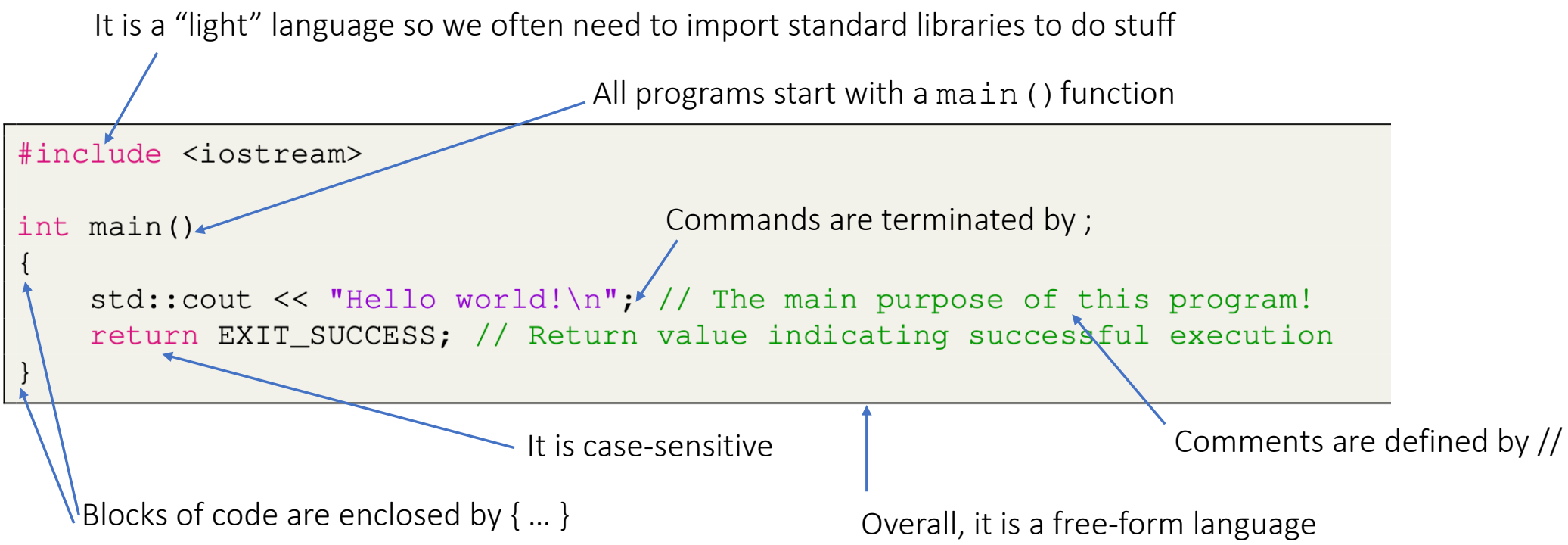
What about C++'s programmer-controlled memory management model?

C++ gives you a lot of power, including letting you access memory you didn't request. This can lead to a memory leaks creating exploits and security risks. For this reason, it is not always the right language to use.



Anatomy of a C++ program

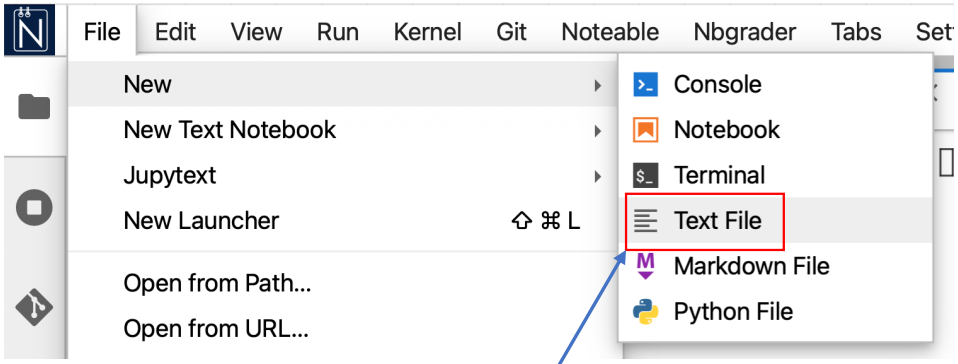
Take the customary first program anyone writes `hello.cpp`. We can highlight a number of essential features about C++ code:




```
1 #include <iostream>
2
3 int main()
4 {
5     std::cout << "Hello world!\n"; // The main purpose of this program!
6     return EXIT_SUCCESS; // Return value indicating successful execution
7 }
```

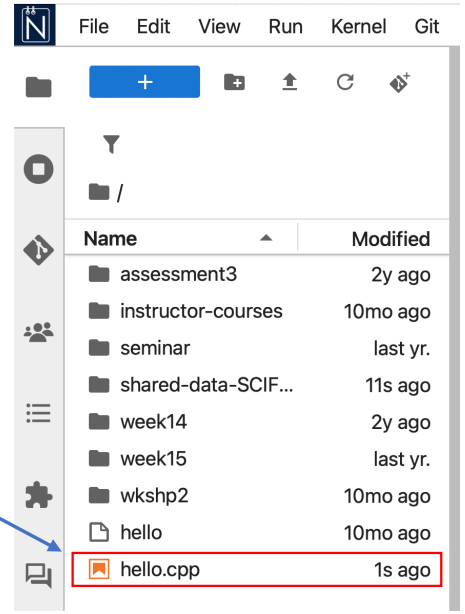
Using *Noteable* for C++ code

C++ source files are just plain text files with a .cpp extension. We can open or create a file in Noteable and use the built-in code editor …



Create a new text file opening the editor

Open existing file in cloud filesystem

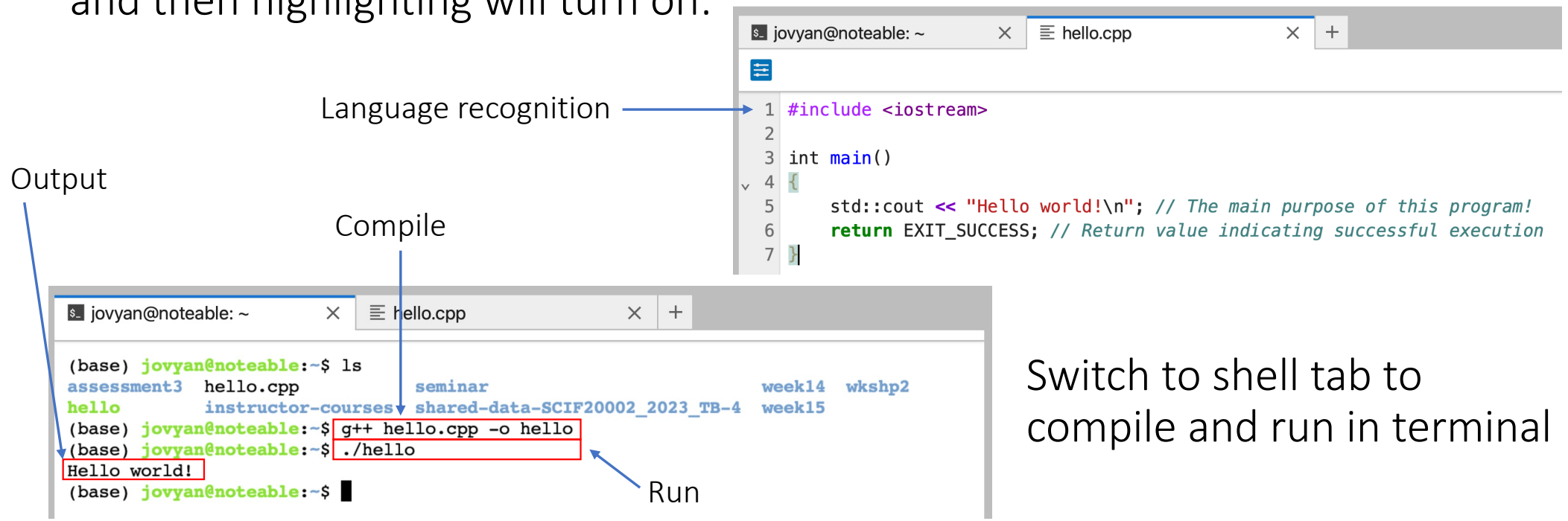


New or existing file is opened as a new tab



Running C++ code on *Noteable*

When editing a .cpp file C++ language syntax highlighting will automatically switch on. If you created a new text file then rename it <something>.cpp, and then highlighting will turn on:



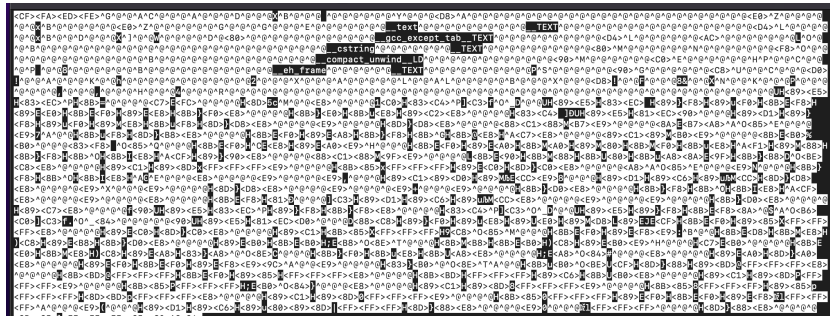
Switch to shell tab to compile and run in terminal

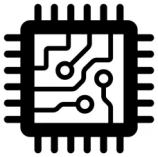
What is compilation?

```
$ g++ hello.cpp -o hello
```

The process of converting source code into binary machine code. It typically has **4 steps**:

```
$ more hello.asm
        .section        __TEXT,__text,regular,pure_instructions
        .build_version macos, 12, 0     sdk_version 12, 1
        .globl  _main                           ## -- Begin function main
        .p2align        4, 0x90
_main:                                  ## @main
        .cfi_startproc
## %bb.0:
        pushq   %rbp
        .cfi_def_cfa_offset 16
        .cfi_offset %rbp, -16
        movq    %rsp, %rbp
        .cfi_def_cfa_register %rbp
        subq    $16, %rsp
        movq    __ZNSt3__14coutE@GOTPCREL(%rip), %rdi
        movl    $0, -4(%rbp)
        leaq    L_.str(%rip), %rsi
        callq   __ZNSt3__1lsINS_11char_traitsIcEEEERNS_13basic_ostreamIcT_EES6_PKc
```









Preprocessing



Compilation



Assembly

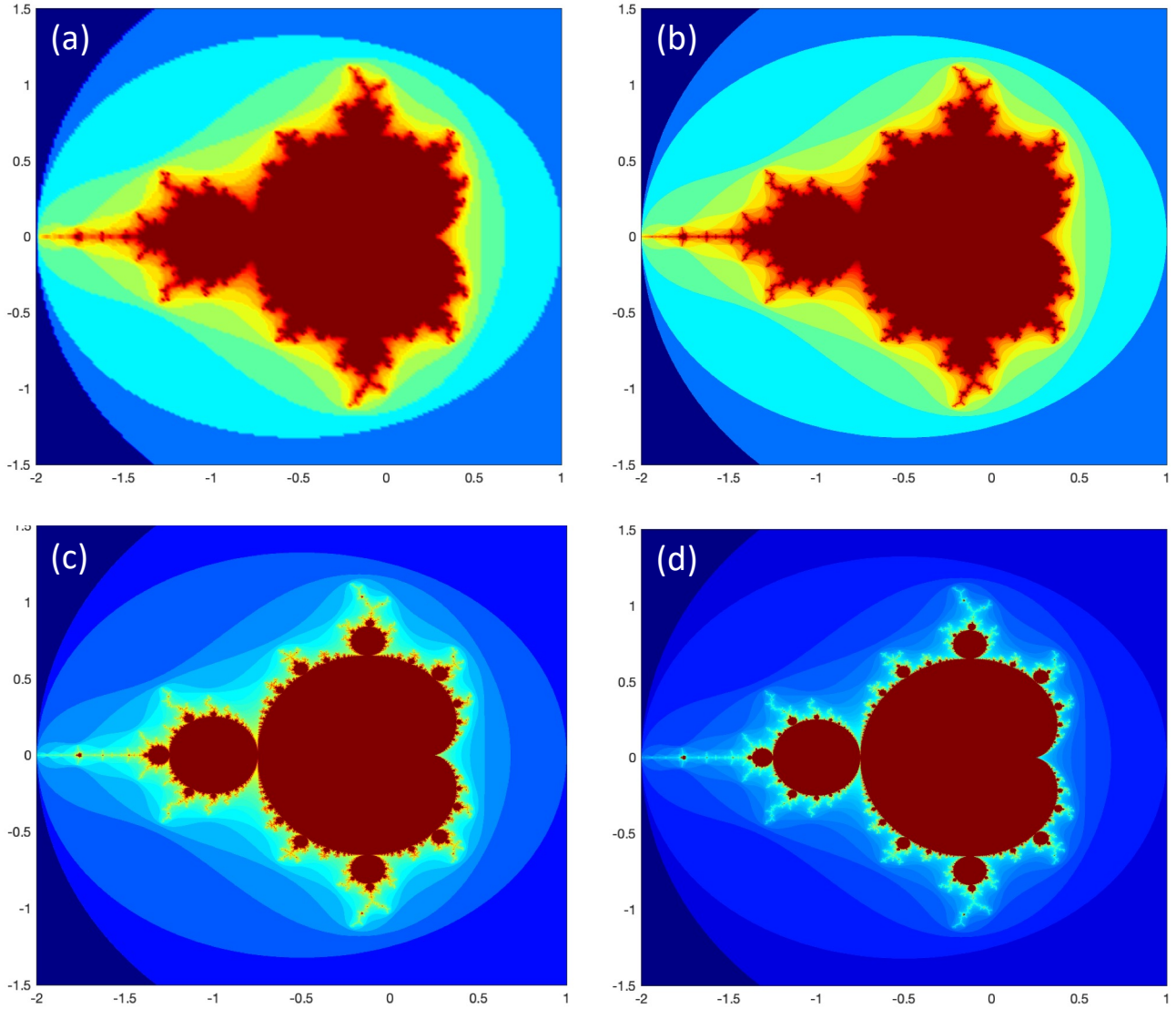


Linking

Exercise example:

You are given C++ code that can compute the well-known Mandelbrot set fractal. The last task of this workshop is to compile it, run it and then post-process the output data to generate a plot similar to these.

Later, I will demonstrate producing a high-resolution calculation using HPC.



What is HPC?



A “supercomputer” is a specially optimized computer that achieves high performance in floating-point operations (FLOPS) central to scientific calculations.

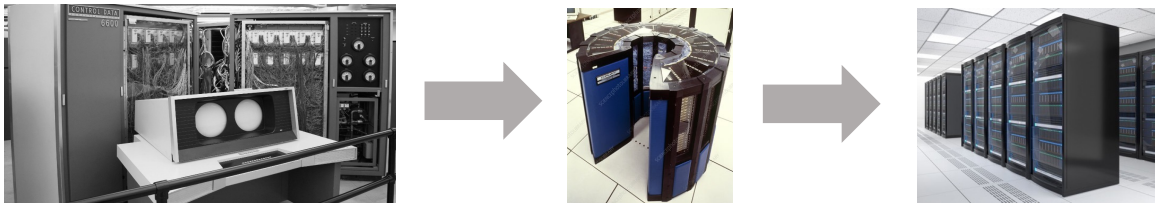


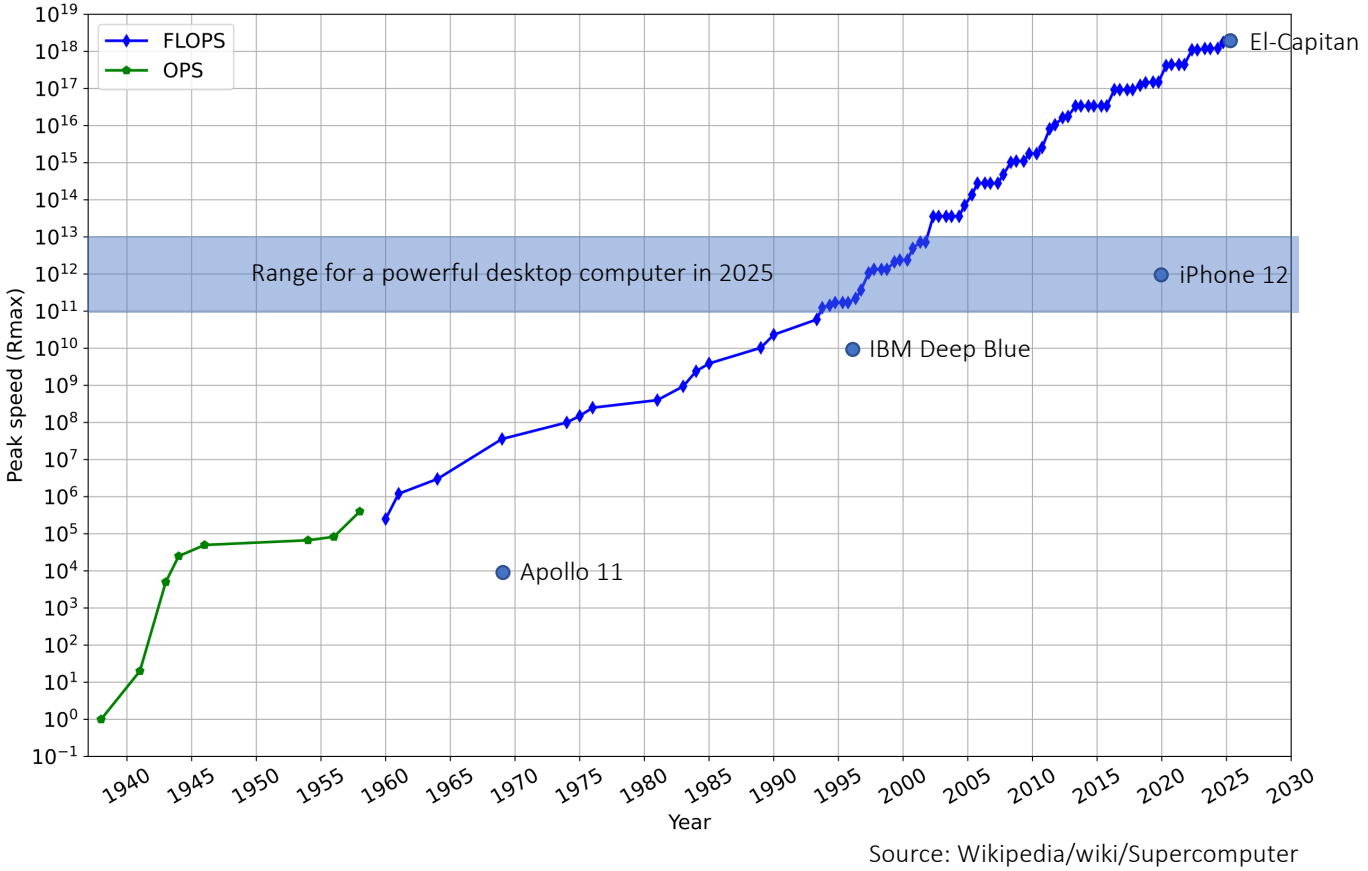
From the 1990’s onwards supercomputers evolved from being a dedicated single machine to being built from 10,000’s of networked “off-the-shelf” machines allowing for massive parallelization.



Since 2017 all the top 500 supercomputers run a Linux-based OS.

What is HPC?





Source: Wikipedia/wiki/Supercomputer

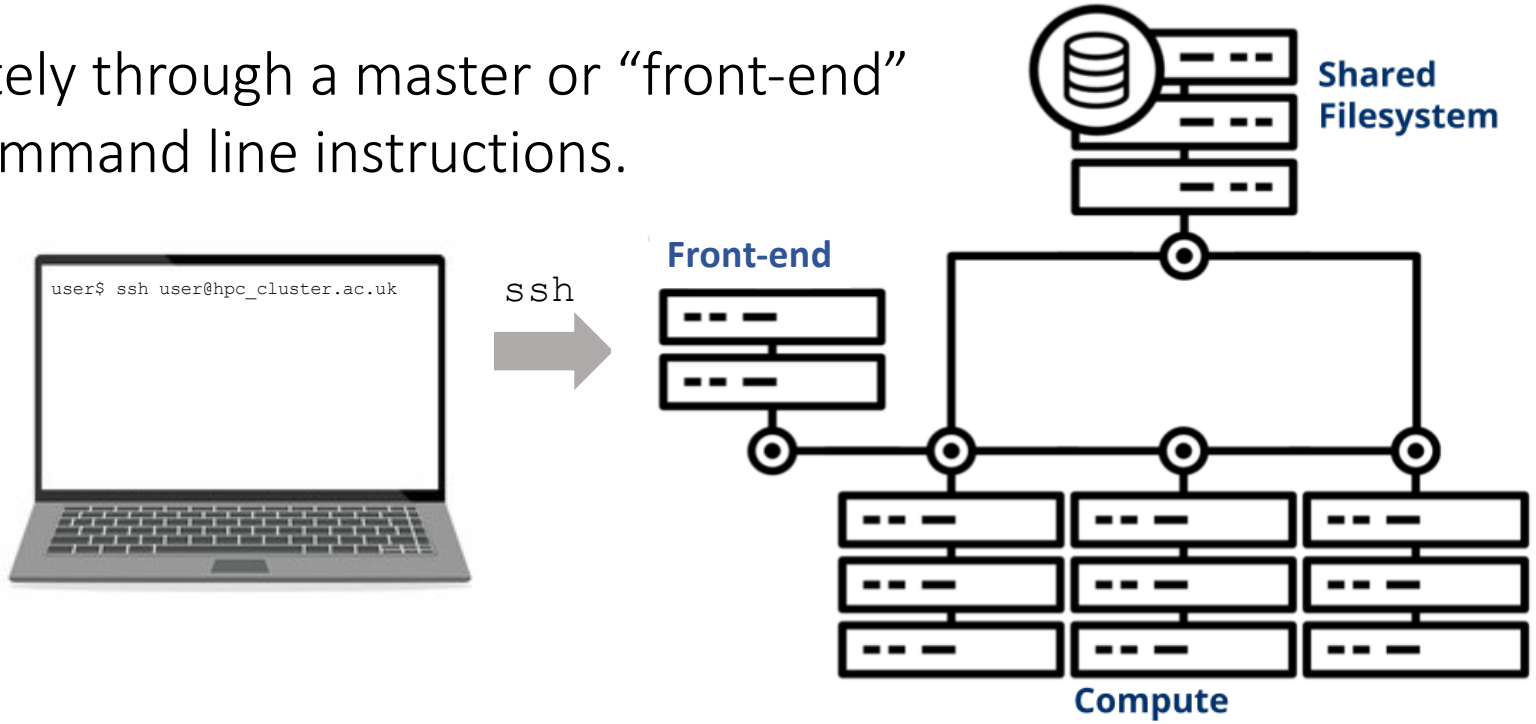
Currently (2025) the most powerful supercomputers can do in excess of 10^{18} FLOPS distributed over millions of CPU cores.

Anatomy of a HPC cluster

Modern HPC cluster comprise many high-powered compute nodes connected via a superfast internal network.

It is accessed remotely through a master or “front-end” node via **ssh** and command line instructions.

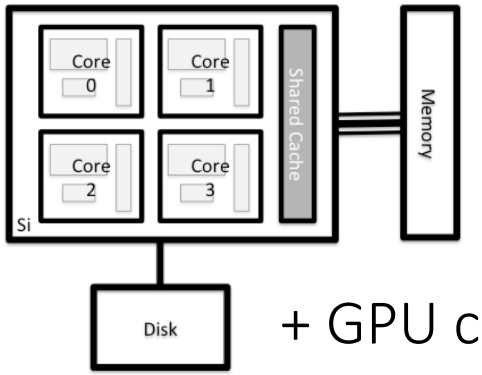
Code and data are stored on a shared filesystem.



HPC compute nodes

A “compute node” in a HPC cluster is individually a very high-powered (often dual multicore (12-24) processors) large memory (4-10GB per core) computer packaged compactly as a **rack-mounted** server blade:



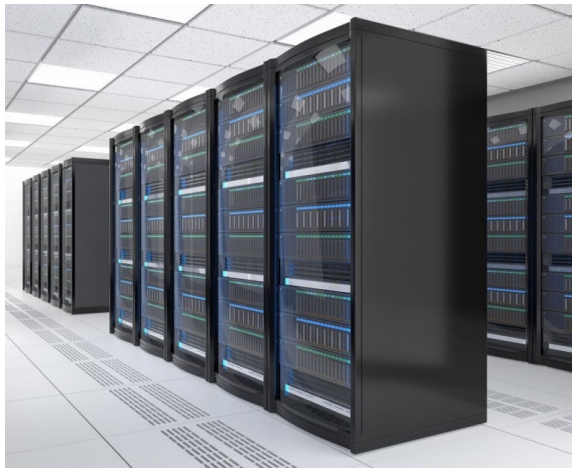


Compute node

+ GPU cards



Server rack



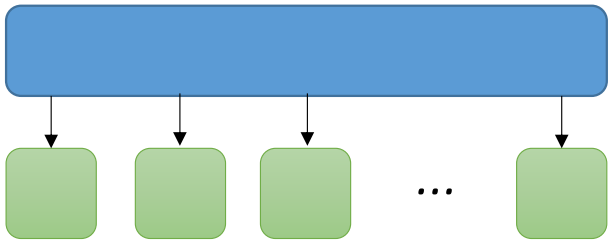
Air-conditioned room

Why do we need HPC?



See upcoming lecture

HPC enables complex scientific calculations that are **impossible** or **infeasibly slow** on a standalone computer. Two cases arise:

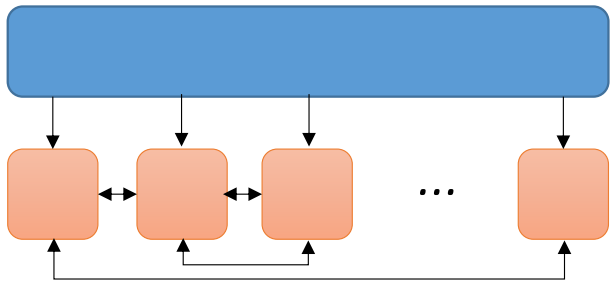


- *"Embarrassingly parallelizable problems"*
  Naturally divides into many independent tasks whose computation requires no communication between them.

Example: *Monte Carlo sampling*

- *"Complex parallelization problems"*
  Only divides into many dependent tasks whose computation requires substantial communication between them.

Example: *High-resolution fluid dynamics*



Workflow using HPC

